



Cognitive Workload Allocation Under Uncertainty

A Stochastic Multiple Knapsack Approach with Workload-Dependent Returns

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Agenda

- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References

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- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References

Motivation: Cognitive Overload, Burnout

- Cognitive overload from excessive demands leads to billions of lost working days annually [Robinson, 2024].
- Productivity depends on attention management rather than rigid time scheduling [Grant, 2019].
- Traditional time management fails because it ignores the finite nature of human lifespan and cognitive capacity [Hart, 2024].
- Chronic illness, burnout risk, and work-family conflict underscore the need for systematic resource allocation that accounts for well-being [Cook and Zill, 2024, Yoo and Lee, 2022].

Outline

- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation**
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References

Problem Setting

Within a finite planning horizon, a team assigns tasks across multiple agents.

- Each agent has limited time, cognitive capacity, and attention (C_j).
- Task i assigned to agent j consumes stochastic size S_{ij} (realized effort).
- The realized return R_{ij} (utility) is also stochastic; it may depend on S_{ij} through

$$R_{ij} = g_{ij}(S_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ij}, \quad \mathbb{E}[\varepsilon_{ij}] = 0.$$

- Deeper engagement can increase value, whereas overload may reduce returns.

Sets, Variables, and Parameters

Sets and indices

- Tasks $i \in \mathcal{I} := \{1, \dots, N\}$
- Agents $j \in \mathcal{J} := \{1, \dots, M\}$

Decision variables

$$x_{ij} = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{task } i \rightarrow \text{agent } j \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Stochastic characteristics

- S_{ij} : stochastic size (effort/attention)
- R_{ij} : stochastic return (utility/value)

Capacity and risk

- $C_j > 0$: agent capacity
- $\alpha \in (0, 1)$: risk tolerance

Stochastic Multiple Knapsack Formulation

$$\max_{\mathbf{x}} \quad \sum_{j \in \mathcal{J}} \sum_{i \in \mathcal{I}} \mathbb{E}[R_{ij}] x_{ij} \quad (\text{Obj})$$

$$\text{s.t.} \quad \sum_{j \in \mathcal{J}} x_{ij} \leq 1, \quad \forall i \in \mathcal{I} \quad (\text{Assign})$$

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\sum_{i \in \mathcal{I}} S_{ij} x_{ij} \leq C_j\right) \geq 1 - \alpha, \quad \forall j \in \mathcal{J} \quad (\text{Chance})$$

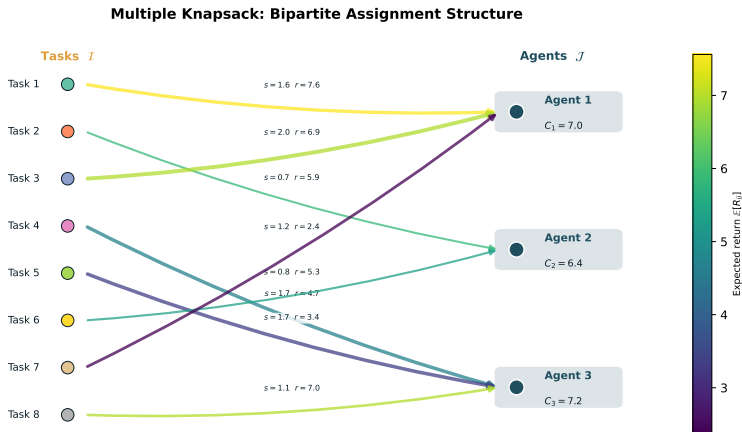
$$x_{ij} \in \{0, 1\}, \quad \forall i, j. \quad (\text{Binary})$$

(Chance) operationalizes cognitive/attention limits via chance constraints. Dependence between S_{ij} and R_{ij} captures workload-dependent productivity.

Outline

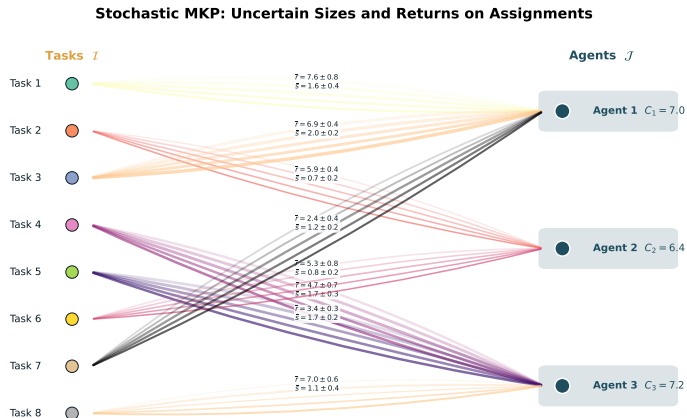
- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition**
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References

Multiple Knapsack Structure



Bipartite assignment: tasks (left) are assigned to agents (right) with capacities C_j . Edge width encodes task size $\mathbb{E}[S_{ij}]$ and color indicates expected return $\mathbb{E}[R_{ij}]$. Each task is assigned to at most one agent (constraint Assign).

Stochastic Sizes and Returns



Stochastic extensions: each assignment edge shows multiple scenario realizations of size S_{ij} (line width) and return R_{ij} (annotation). The chance constraint (Chance) limits the probability that total realized load exceeds agent capacity.

Outline

- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context**
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References

Stochastic Knapsack: Cutting Planes and Dominance

- Büyüktaktın [2023] derive scenario dominance cuts for multi-stage **stochastic MIPs** applied to the dynamic multi-dimensional knapsack. Strong dominance cuts reduce solution time with 0.06% average deviation from optimality.
- Büyüktaktın [2022] generalize this via Stage-t Scenario Dominance for risk-averse (mean-CVaR) knapsack problems, achieving one-to-two orders of magnitude speedup.
- Joung et al. [2023] **compare LP relaxation bounds** for the robust knapsack problem and show that extended formulations yield identical bounds.

Distributionally Robust and Risk-averse Knapsack

- Bos et al. [2024] approximate the stochastic knapsack with periodic scheduled arrivals using Wasserstein Distributed Robust Optimization (DRO), producing robust healthcare surgical schedules.
- Ding et al. [2022] propose a target-based DRO knapsack with uncertain profit and capacity, reformulated as a **second-order conic program**.
- Merzifonluoglu and Geunes [2021] study the risk-averse static stochastic knapsack with CVaR and mean-standard deviation objectives, deriving efficient heuristics for normally distributed resource consumption.
- Boonstra et al. [2025] solve a robust multi-item newsvendor with budget constraint using a greedy knapsack algorithm under moment ambiguity.

Solution Algorithms for Stochastic Programs

- Chen and Luedtke [2022] analyze sample average approximation for two-stage programs without complete recourse, proving exponential convergence of recourse likelihood.
- Larsen et al. [2024] accelerate L-shaped methods via supervised ML, solving stochastic multi-knapsack instances in 20% of the time with less than 0.1% optimality gap.
- Lefebvre et al. [2024] reformulate adjustable robust optimization with discrete uncertainty and apply **branch-and-cut to the multiple knapsack problem with uncertain weights**.
- Lyu et al. [2022] unify **responsive, adaptive, and anticipative allocation policies** for the stochastic knapsack through persistency values.

Assignment, Scheduling, and Workforce Planning

- Rezaeian et al. [2024] model the stochastic assignment of projects to managers via **multi-stage stochastic integer programming** with heuristic algorithms for large instances.
- Nasirian et al. [2025] solve multiskilled workforce staffing and scheduling via logic-based Benders decomposition, achieving 29x speedup over direct MILP solving.
- Cavagnini et al. [2020] use two-stage stochastic programming for production planning under uncertain learning rates, with insights on cross-training and worker assignment.
- Novak et al. [2022] connect stochastic parallel machine scheduling to an inflatable stochastic knapsack pricing subproblem within **branch-and-price**.

Outline

- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches**
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References

Possible solution methodology

- Benders decomposition:

- ▶ Master problem: choose task selection and assignment decisions $x_{ij} \in \{0, 1\}$.
- ▶ Subproblems: for each agent/scenario, compute overload/risk and generate Benders cuts.

Possible expected results

- R1: Return-Risk trade-off.
 - ▶ As risk tolerance α decreases, optimal expected return decreases, while overload violation rate drops sharply.
- R2: Allocation pattern changes.
 - ▶ Tighter α makes the system more distributed: tasks are spread across agents to avoid single-point overload.
 - ▶ Fewer tasks with high variance / highly uncertain durations are selected.
- R3: Impact of stress-performance dependence.
 - ▶ If $R_{ij} = g_{ij}(S_{ij}) + \varepsilon$ and g_{ij} decreases under high workload, the optimal policy avoids near-capacity assignments more aggressively.

Outline

- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways**
- 7 References

Key Takeaways

- The formulation models cognitive resource allocation as a multiple knapsack problem with stochastic sizes and returns, capturing workload-dependent productivity via $R_{ij} = g_{ij}(S_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ij}$.
- **Chance constraints** operationalize cognitive/attention limits, controlling overload risk while retaining assignment flexibility.
- Scenario dominance cuts [Büyüktaktakın, 2023], DRO reformulations [Bos et al., 2024, Ding et al., 2022], and ML-accelerated decomposition [Larsen et al., 2024] are natural tools for scaling the model to organizational settings.

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- 1 Motivation
- 2 Problem Formulation
- 3 Visual Intuition
- 4 Methodological Context
- 5 Solution Approaches
- 6 Takeaways
- 7 References**

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